

16 PEOPLE AND SOCIETY



He who is unable to live in society, or who has no need because he is sufficient for himself, must be either a beast or a God.

Aristotle

Good manners will open doors that the best education cannot.

Clarence Thomas

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **society:** individuals, people, system, rules, norms, manners, social etiquette, social behaviour, protocol, models, ethics, etiquette, welfare system, benefits, social security
- **universal social rules:** politeness, respect, tolerance, empathy, expressing thanks, apologising, forgiving, accepting, following rules, addressing people, offering hospitality, praising others, leading conversations politely, responding to invitations
- **social events:** protocol, conventions, hosting guests, dining, clothing
- **international etiquette:** tolerance, respect, cultural awareness
- **conversational etiquette:** choice of topics, listening to each other, proximity, physical contact, gestures
- **dining etiquette/hosting etiquette:** to arrive on time, to invite for dinner, to bring a gift/present, to make a toast (*povedat prípitok*), to eat neatly, to sip soup, to pour tea, to tear a piece from a roll
- **clothing/dressing etiquette:** occasions, formal, casual
- **loss of manners:** cause and effect
 - the role of society, lack of models, “practise what you preach”, influence of the media, generation gap, freedom of personal expression, moral code, carelessness
 - to pick up from role models, to observe role models, to raise ill-mannered children, to break rules
- **people in need:** the homeless, the retired, the unemployed, the sick, the old, the disabled, the mistreated, the underprivileged, asylum houses, old people’s homes, orphanages, hospices

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. Why do rules/norms exist in every society?
2. How can an individual benefit from being a member of a society?
3. Can you imagine living in isolation? How different would your life be?
4. What social rules are people expected to follow?
5. Can you describe the behaviour of people who do not respect social norms?
6. Who creates rules of behaviour?

7. Are there any differences in social rules in different cultures?
8. Give some examples of certain norms/behaviour typical for certain cultures.
9. What do you know about table manners in your country?
10. Can you think of any social events which require certain etiquette? Give examples.

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

SOCIAL ETIQUETTE

Living in a society **requires** following certain rules of behaviour. If we want to be accepted by the society we live in, we should know these rules and try to follow them. Different rules are followed at home, at work, or at **social events**, such as dinners. Other **conventions are kept** when doing business. These rules and conventions concern **appearance** (how to dress for a **particular occasion**) and behaviour (greetings, **addressing people** or topics of conversation). **Ethics**, the study of moral rules, norms and **manners**, analyses what is right and what is wrong. Etiquette, known also as protocol, describes formal rules or traditions of behaviour in a certain society and culture. It **prescribes** the ways in which people communicate with each other and show their respect for other people. Modern etiquette tells us how to greet people with warmth and respect, offer **hospitality** to guests, wear clothing **appropriate** for certain occasions, **contribute** to conversations without dominating them, listen to speakers, offer a chair, help those who need **assistance**, eat **neatly** and quietly, **avoid disturbing** others with loud music or unnecessary noise, **arrive on time** when expected and **respond** to invitations **promptly**.

1. What is the difference between etiquette and ethics mentioned in the passage above?
2. Why is it said that it is necessary to know and follow the rules in society?

PRACTISE WHAT YOU PREACH

It is **extremely important** to show children what is right and what is wrong from an early age. Children and young people **observe** moral rules **unconsciously** and behave according to what they see. They **pick them up** from their parents, teachers and friends. Parents should therefore be models of appropriate social behaviour. It is from our family that our behaviour is formed. If parents speak **rudely**, children will imitate their “models”. If parents only have TV dinners, children will not know how to behave at the table. Small things, such as talking to people with respect, listening to them, showing **empathy**, **praising** others for their **achievements**, should be common in every family. Their absence leads to the **raising** of **ill-mannered** children. Parents should also be careful and “practise what they **preach**”.

Rules of social behaviour are also taught at school. At most schools children can attend either religion or ethics classes. Both of them try to teach children and young people how to **differentiate** between good and **evil**, between what is **moral** and what is immoral.

3. What is the role of parents and teachers in modern societies?
4. In what sense is "practise what you preach" related to the passage you have just read?

LOSS OF MANNERS: CAUSE AND EFFECT

The **loss of manners** has become a serious problem in modern societies. Nowadays, many children are educated by the media. Cartoon characters, movies, games and music are often rude and violent. Different **pseudo-idols** from various reality shows influence young people's **values**. Only people who look good and have a lot of money are **considered** successful. **Acquired** negative **patterns** of behaviour in childhood change little, if at all, later in adulthood. **Huge** differences between how children are raised nowadays and how our parents and grandparents were raised has led to big **generation gaps**. According to some people, etiquette limits **freedom of personal expression**. Others think that sharing the same **moral code** makes life easier because many **misunderstandings** can as a result be avoided. **Breaking morals** leads to ignorance, **carelessness**, misunderstandings, useless arguments and conflicts with both people and the **law**.

5. What leads to children being ill-mannered?
6. What kind of behaviour is typical of ill-mannered people?

CARING FOR OTHERS

On the one hand, there are people who often have to solve moral dilemmas. For doctors or lawyers, for example, it is sometimes not easy to decide how to behave ethically. On the other hand, there are those who **struggle** daily **with** their lives in the streets. Homelessness is a big social problem that should not be ignored. Loss of regular **income** and the **ensuing** impossibility of **paying back a mortgage** are common reasons why people become homeless. They live in **abandoned** houses, parks and streets without any water, electricity or gas. Charities and different social programmes help them by providing them with food, clothing and medical treatment. **Asylum houses** provide them with **shelter** from unsafe streets and cold winters. Besides the homeless, there are many other **people in need**: the old, the sick, **the disabled**, the abandoned, the addicted, the unemployed, etc. There are special social programmes and **ongoing projects** that aim to support those who need it most. A negative attitude of people towards the homeless, the addicts and the disabled is a serious moral and social problem in many countries. **Reluctance** and ignorance might lead to their social isolation and lack of motivation in wishing to **blend in with** other people.

7. How does the writer describe homelessness?
8. What is the attitude of society towards people in need?

□ VOCABULARY LIST

abandoned – opustený
achievement – úspech
acquired [ə'kwaiə(r)əd] – získaný
appearance – výzor
appropriate – primeraný
assistance – pomoc
asylum house [ə'saɪləm haʊs] – azylový dom
to blend in with – splynúť s
carelessness – nedbalosť, ľahostajnosť
to consider – považovať
to contribute – prispievať
to differentiate – rozlišovať
empathy [ɛmpəθɪ] – empatia
ensuing [ɪn'su:ɪŋ] – nasledujúci
ethics [eθɪks] – etika
evil – zlo
freedom of expression – sloboda prejavu
generation gap – generačný rozdiel
hospitality – pohostinnosť
huge – obrovský
ill-mannered – nevychovaný
income – príjem
law [lɔ:] – zákon
loss of manners – strata spôsobov
manner – spôsob
misunderstanding – nepochopenie
moral code – morálny kódex
neatly [ni:tli] – úhľadne
observe – pozorovať
occasion – príležitosť

ongoing project – prebiehajúci projekt
particular – určitý
pattern – vzor
people in need – ľudia v núdzi
to pick up – pochytiť, naučiť sa
to praise [preɪz] – chváliť
to preach [pri:tʃ] – kázať
to prescribe – predpísať
pseudo-idol [sju:ðə aɪdl] – pseudoidol
to raise [reɪz] – vychovávať
reluctance [rɪlʌktəns] – zdráhavosť
to require – vyžadovať
rudely – drzo
shelter [ʃeltə] – útočisko
social event – spoločenská udalosť
to struggle with – bojovať s
the disabled – postihnutí
unconsciously [ʌŋkənʃəsli] – podvedome
value [vælju:] – hodnota

to address people – osloviť ľudí
to arrive on time – prísť včas
to avoid disturbing – vyhýbať sa
 vyrušovaniu
to break morals – porušiť morálku
to keep conventions – dodržiavať konven-
 cie
to pay back a mortgage [mɔ:ɡɪdʒ] – splatiť
 hypotéku
to respond promptly – reagovať okamžite

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 Who might say the following sentences during a visit to someone's home?
 The hosts or the guests? Write your answers in the space provided.



Example: Sorry, we're late. We got stuck in a traffic jam.

guests

1. The food was delicious. Thank you very much.

2. Let me get you another drink.

3. Welcome to our house!

4. May I take your coat?

5. May I help you with the dishes?

6. Shall we go? It's getting late. _____
7. I'll call you a taxi if you want. _____
8. Here's a small gift for you. _____
9. Would you like some more soup? _____
10. Make yourself at home! _____
11. May I use your bathroom? _____
12. Please make yourself comfortable. _____
13. Thank you very much, but I'm afraid I'm full. _____

Task 2 Rick and Gina have been going out with each other for three years. Gina's parents invited Rick to have dinner with them. Rick didn't know much about the table manners that were common in Gina's family. Read about Rick's behaviour and say what he did wrong. Write what he should have done/shouldn't have done/could have done/might have done instead. What do you think Rita told him after his visit? 

Example: Rick never thanked them for inviting him.

He should have thanked them for the invitation.

1. He came half an hour late for dinner.

2. He didn't apologise for coming late.

3. He kissed Gina's mother and bowed to Gina's father.

4. He didn't bring any gifts for Gina's mother and father.

5. His soup was very hot, so he was sipping it.

6. He refused to eat the meat because it was too tough.

7. He said that he didn't like the meat very much.

8. He asked three times for a glass of wine.

9. He spilt red wine on the white tablecloth.

10. He made a phone call to his friend during dinner.

11. He started a discussion about politics with Gina's dad, who had controversial opinions.

12. He spoke with his mouth full and very loudly.

13. He didn't offer to help clean the table up after dinner.

14. He left after midnight.
